GROUP 3 / FIVE-MINUTE READING BRIEF

How teams handle conflict

Moving Beyond Relationship and Task Conflict: Toward a Process-State Perspective
Leslie A. DeChurch, Jessica R. Mesmer-Magnus & Dan Doty (2013)

How a team handles its differences is at least as important as what those differences are.

1. Separate the disagreement from the response

The paper distinguishes **conflict states** from **conflict processes**. States are shared perceptions about the nature and intensity of disagreement. Processes are members' interactions as they work through those differences. Both help explain team effectiveness.

Conflict states: what the disagreement concerns	Definition
Task conflict	Differences over goals, ideas, and strategies for doing the work.
Relationship conflict	Interpersonal incompatibilities, including personality clashes and differences in interpersonal style.

2. Recognize four ways of handling differences

Conflict process	Defining behavior
Openness	Express different views, discuss concerns, challenge ideas, and remain open to changing your mind.
Collaborating	Investigate underlying concerns and work toward a solution that benefits the parties involved.
Competing	Push for your own position to prevail; dominate, contend, or force an outcome.
Avoiding	Move away from the disagreement instead of engaging with it.

Openness versus collaboration: both involve discussing differences. Collaboration additionally emphasizes developing mutually beneficial solutions. The paper analyzes them separately.

What the research shows

3. Team-focused processes are associated with better outcomes

The meta-analysis combines **45 independent studies involving 3,218 teams**. It examines both **performance** (such as decision quality and supervisor ratings) and **affective outcomes** (such as satisfaction and willingness to continue working together).

The authors classify openness and collaboration as **collectivistic**: they integrate differences while prioritizing the whole team. Avoiding and competing are **individualistic**: they preserve separate positions or subgroups. These terms describe conflict interactions, rather than national cultures.

Process	Average association with performance
Openness	**+0.33** | Positive
Collaborating	**+0.31** | Positive
Competing	**-0.23** | Negative
Avoiding	**-0.17** | Negative

Source: Table 4, p. 564. Values are reliability-corrected correlations, not percentage changes in performance. Competing has the strongest negative average estimate of these four; overlapping uncertainty intervals do not establish a definitive ranking.

4. Handling conflict adds explanatory value

After accounting for task and relationship conflict, collaborating, competing, and avoiding explain approximately **13 additional percentage points of variance** in both performance and affective outcomes. Openness, analyzed separately, adds about **8 points** for performance and **4 points** for affective outcomes. These are explanatory statistics, not promised improvements.

5. Conflict and behavior can reinforce each other

Interaction patterns shape members' perceptions of conflict, and those perceptions shape later interactions. Processes are therefore a practical target for change. The findings favor expressing and examining differences openly, then integrating concerns into a joint solution. **Task disagreement is not automatically beneficial.** Relationship conflict remains particularly damaging to the team's emotional health.

Read the findings with three limits in mind

Most evidence is **correlational**, so it does not establish cause and effect. Studies use **different measures** of conflict processes. Some relationships, especially those involving avoidance, rely on **relatively few studies**. Avoidance is not uniformly harmful: temporarily setting aside an irrelevant personal dispute can sometimes preserve task focus.

Reference: DeChurch, L. A., Mesmer-Magnus, J. R., & Doty, D. (2013). Moving beyond relationship and task conflict: Toward a process-state perspective. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 98*(4), 559-578. doi:10.1037/a0032896